



Shinogi (ridge)

Menuki (ornamentation) in the form of Shimazu heraldry

► TANTO

Date 1792

Origin Japan

Length 28.5cm (11¼in)

A *tanto* was a sword or dagger with a blade less than 31cm (12in) in length. It was often worn as an alternative to a *wakizashi*. This example is black-lacquered, with the scabbard housing a *kogai* on the outer face and a *kozuka* at the rear.



TANTO



SCABBARD



KOGAI



KOZUKA

Blade is a composite of iron and steel



Kissaki or point section



Black lacquered wooden saya (scabbard)

► TSUBA

Date 19th century

Origin Japan

Material Iron, gold

Diameter 6.5–7cm (2¼–3in)

Originally, *tsuba* (hand guards) were relatively plain, becoming more decorative later. The example with a silhouetted goose flying in front of the moon and clouds (left) is enhanced with gold overlay, while the *tsuba* with a floral motif (right) is chiselled out of an iron plate.



Decoration probably by Owari school



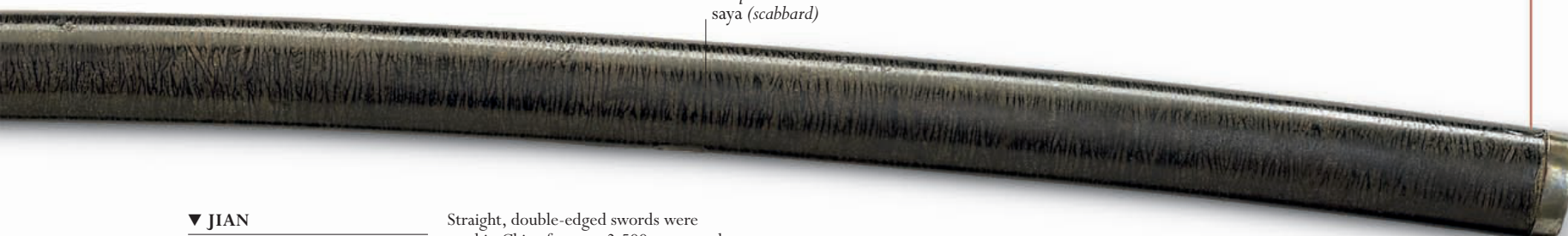
Signed by master swordsmith Masayoshi



Blade more than 60.6cm (23½in) long

Kissaki or point section

Lacquered wooden saya (scabbard)



▼ JIAN

Date 19th century

Origin China

Weight 950g (33½oz)

Length 88cm (34½in)

Straight, double-edged swords were used in China for over 2,500 years, and were regarded as one of the four traditional weapons. The blades were made of hard steel, with a softer steel welded to each side. Many had a medial ridge.

Medial ridge

